

Chapter 4

Software Evaluation and Costing

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Project Evaluation

Project evaluation is a **process of collecting and analyzing information** in order to **understand the progress, success, and effectiveness of a project**.

Evaluation is an important aspect of project management It can **facilitate the successful completion of the project, and inform decisions about the future** of both the project at hand and other projects.

Project evaluation is a crucial step taken at the **beginning** of a project to assess its overall feasibility and alignment with organizational goals.

It involves a comprehensive analysis of strategic, technical, and economic aspects, and the results guide decision-making on whether to proceed with the project.

Why project evaluation is important:

1. Strategic Alignment:

- Evaluating a project helps ensure that it aligns with the strategic goals and objectives of the organization.
- This alignment ensures that resources are invested in projects that contribute to the overall mission and vision.

2. Resource Optimization:

- By assessing the feasibility and potential outcomes of a project, organizations can optimize resource allocation.
- This includes financial resources, human resources, and time.

3. Risk Management:

- Project evaluation includes risk analysis, allowing organizations to identify potential challenges and uncertainties.
- Understanding risks in advance enables better risk management strategies and mitigation plans to be put in place.

4. Decision Making:

- Project evaluation provides crucial information for decision-makers, such as senior management and project stakeholders.
- It helps them make informed choices about whether to proceed with a project, select among alternative projects, or adjust project parameters.

5. Economic Viability:

- Assessing the economic feasibility of a project through cost-benefit analysis and financial forecasting helps organizations understand the potential return on investment.
- This information is vital for making decisions on resource allocation and justifying project expenditures.

Project evaluation is done by

- Senior management
- Project manager/coordinator
- Team leader

When

- Usually at the beginning of the project e.g. Step 0 of Step Wise Framework

How Can the Results of a Project Evaluation Be Used?

The **purpose** of any **evaluation is to provide information for action** (e.g., decision-making, strategic planning, program modification).

Once evaluation information is available, it should be **distributed among the project stakeholders and integrated into management practices**.

If this is not done, evaluation is a waste of organization resources.

The results of project evaluation can be used to:

- identify ways to improve or shift project activities,
- facilitate changes in the project plan,
- prepare project reports (e.g., mid-term reports, final reports),
- Inform internal and external stakeholders about the project,
- plan for the sustainability of the project,
- learn more about the environment in which the project is being or has been carried out,

Evaluation Criteria:

1. Strategic Assessment:

- Examining how the project aligns with the strategic goals of the organization.

2. Technical Assessment:

- Evaluating the technical feasibility and challenges associated with the project.

3. Economic Assessment:

- Assessing the economic viability of the project, including potential costs and benefits.

Evaluation Methods:

1. Cost-Benefit Analysis:

- Analyzing the costs and benefits associated with the project to determine its economic feasibility.

2. Cash Flow Forecasting:

- Predicting the cash flow associated with the project over time.

3. Cost-Benefit Evaluation Techniques:

- Employing various techniques to evaluate the costs and benefits, such as Return on Investment (ROI) calculations.

4. Risk Evaluation:

- Identifying and analyzing potential risks associated with the project.

Strategic Planning:

Strategic planning is **defined as an organization's process of defining its strategy**, or direction and making decisions on allocating its resources to pursue this strategy, including its capital and people

it deals with:

- what do we do?
- for whom do we do it?
- how do we excel?

Strategic Assessment:

Strategic assessment is the **first criteria** for project evaluation

- For evaluating and managing the projects, the individual projects should be seen as components of a programme.
- Hence need to do programme management.

Programme Management:

D.C. Ferns defined “a programme as a **group of projects that are managed in a co-ordinated way to gain benefits** that would not be possible were the projects to be managed independently”.

A programme in this context is a “**collection of projects that all contribute to the same overall organization goals**”.

Effective programme management requires that there is a **well defined programme goal** and that all the organization’s projects are selected and tuned to contribute to this goal”

Evaluating of project is depends on:

- How it contributes to programme goal.
- It is viability [capability of developing or useful].
- Timing.
- Resourcing.

For successful strategic assessment, there should be a strategic plan which defines:

- Organization's objectives.
- Provides context for defining programme .
- Provides context for defining programme goals.
- Provide context for accessing individual project.

Issue and question mentioned during the strategic assessment:

1. Objectives:

- **Question:** How will the proposed system contribute to the organization's stated objectives? How, for example, might it contribute to an increase in market share?

- **Explanation:** Understanding how the new system aligns with the organization's objectives is crucial. In this case, the focus is on identifying specific ways the proposed system can contribute to achieving organizational goals, such as increasing market share.

2. IS Plan:

- **Question:** How does the proposed system fit into the Information Systems (IS) plan? Which existing system(s) will it replace/interface with? How will it interact with systems proposed for later development?
- **Explanation:** This addresses the integration of the new system into the existing IT infrastructure. Compatibility with current systems and future development plans is essential for a seamless transition and ongoing efficiency.

3. Organization Structure:

- **Question:** What effect will the new system have on the existing departmental and organization structure? For example, will a new sales order processing system overlap existing sales and stock control functions?
- **Explanation:** Changes in the organization's structure may be necessary due to the introduction of new systems. It's essential to consider potential overlaps, redundancies, or restructuring needs.

4. MIS (Management Information System):

- **Question:** What information will the system provide and at what levels in the organization? In what ways will it complement or enhance the existing Management Information System?
- **Explanation:** Understanding the information the new system will generate and how it integrates with the existing management information system is crucial for effective decision-making.

5. Personnel:

- **Question:** In what way will the proposed system affect manning levels and the existing employee skill base? What are the implications for the organization's overall policy on staff development?
- **Explanation:** The introduction of a new system may impact the workforce, requiring adjustments in terms of staffing levels and skill requirements. This question addresses the human resource implications and the need for staff development.

6. Image:

- **Question:** What, if any, will be the effect on customers' attitudes towards the organization? Will the

adoption of, say, an automated system conflict with the objectives of providing a friendly service?

- **Explanation:** The perception of customers is crucial. This question focuses on understanding how the proposed system might impact the organization's image and whether it aligns with the goals of providing a positive customer experience.

Portfolio management

Project Portfolio management provides an **overview of all the projects that an organization is undertaking or is considering**. It **prioritizes the allocation of resources** to projects and **decides which projects should be accepted and which existing ones should be dropped**.

The concerns of Project Portfolio management include:

- Identifying which project proposals are worth implementation;
- Assessing the amount of risk of failure that a potential project has;
- Deciding how to share limited resources, including staff time and finance, between projects;

- Being aware of the dependencies between projects;
- Ensuring that projects do not duplicate benefits;
- Ensuring that necessary developments have been inadvertently been missed.

The three key aspects of Project Portfolio management are:

1. Portfolio definition
2. Portfolio management
3. Portfolio optimization

Technical Assessment:

When we talk about technical assessment for a project, we're essentially looking at **how well the proposed system fits with the hardware and software that are available.**

Technical assessment of a proposed system evaluates **functionality** against available:

- Hardware
- Software

Hardware:

Assessment: In a technical assessment, we'd evaluate whether the proposed system can work effectively with the existing hardware.

For example, if the system requires a lot of processing power, we need to ensure that the hardware in place can handle it without slowing down or causing issues.

Software:

Assessment: We assess whether the proposed system can run smoothly and efficiently with the available software. This involves checking compatibility - making sure that the software required by the system is compatible with the existing software environment.

For instance, if the proposed system needs to integrate with a specific database management system, we need to ensure that it's compatible with the software already in use.

Limitations:

1. Nature of Solutions Produced by Strategic Information Systems Plan:

. Explanation:

- When we talk about the nature of solutions produced by a strategic information systems plan, we're looking at what kind of outcomes or results we can expect from the plan.
- Strategic information systems planning involves making **long-term decisions about how to use technology to achieve business goals**.
- However, it's **important to understand that not all solutions** produced by these plans may be perfect or completely solve the problems they're meant to address.

. Limitation:

- The limitation here is that the solutions proposed by a strategic information systems plan may not always meet all expectations or solve all problems effectively.

- Sometimes, the solutions may be too complex, not fully address the needs of the organization, or encounter unforeseen challenges during implementation.

2. Cost of Solution and Cost-Benefit Analysis:

• Explanation:

- Cost is a crucial factor when considering any technological solution.
- It involves **not just the initial investment required to implement the solution but also ongoing expenses** such as maintenance, training, and upgrades.
- Conducting a cost-benefit analysis helps in evaluating whether the benefits gained from implementing a solution outweigh the costs associated with it.

• Limitation:

- The limitation here is that implementing technological solutions often involves significant costs, and it's **not always guaranteed that the benefits will outweigh these costs.**

- Additionally, **accurately estimating both the costs and benefits can be challenging**, as there may be unforeseen expenses or benefits that are difficult to quantify.

The **importance of technology assessment** can be highlighted through several key points:

1. Identifying Problems:

- Technology assessment serves as a **tool to identify underlying problems within a project**.
- By thoroughly reviewing production processes, systems, and equipment, it helps reveal constraints that may not be immediately obvious.
- These constraints can range from technical issues like insufficient production capacity to non-technical challenges such as skill gaps among staff.
- This investigative tool provides transparency and helps in understanding the root causes of problems.

2. Identifying Solutions:

- Once technical problems are identified, technology assessment facilitates the exploration of potential solutions.
- It offers the opportunity to consider various options, such as implementing new equipment, adopting different crop varieties, or making changes to existing processes.
- Through systematic analysis, more creative, better-fitting, and cost-effective solutions can be discovered.
- This process is crucial, especially when grant budgets are limited, as it helps in understanding the trade-offs between different technical solutions and enables informed decision-making to optimize resource allocation.

3. Communication Tool:

- Technology assessment also serves as a means of communication.
- The documentation of background research and analysis helps in explaining the rationale behind project design and budget decisions.

- This clarity enhances communication among stakeholders, enabling them to brainstorm solutions collaboratively and identify any potential issues that may have been overlooked.
- Moreover, a well-presented technology assessment reduces the likelihood of questions or misunderstandings from funding agencies, leading to better understanding and support for the project proposal.
- Additionally, it serves as a valuable record and resource for the grantee, allowing them to revisit and reconsider options if needed in the future.

Economic Assessment:

- Consider whether the project is the best among other options
- Prioritise the projects so that the resources can be allocated effectively if several projects are underway
- The economic assessment can be done by the following ways:

- ✓ Cost-benefit analysis
- ✓ Cash flow forecasting
- ✓ Various cost-benefit evaluation techniques

Cost Benefit Analysis:

- It is one of the important and common way of carrying “economic assessment” of a proposed information System.
- This is **done by comparing the expected costs** of development and operation of the system with its **benefits**.
- Any project aiming at **return on investment** must provide a greater benefit than putting that investment in a bank.
- So it takes an account:
 - Expected cost of development of system
 - Expected cost of operation of system
 - Benefits obtained

- Assessment is based on:
 - Whether the **estimated costs are executed by the estimated income.**
 - And by other benefits
- For achieving benefit where there is a scarce resource, projects will be prioritized and resources are allocated effectively.
- The standard way of evaluating economic benefits of any project is done by “cost benefit analysis”
- Cost benefit analysis comprises of two steps:
 - Step-1: identifying and estimating all of the costs and benefits of carrying out the project.
 - Step-2: expressing these costs and benefits in common units.

Step 1: Identifying and Estimating Costs and Benefits

1. Development Cost of System:

- **Explanation:** This involves estimating the **expenses associated with building or creating the new system.** It includes costs such as software development, hardware purchases, hiring

developers, and any other resources needed for the development process.

- **Example:** For a sales order processing system, development costs might include expenses for designing the software, purchasing necessary equipment, and paying developers for their time and expertise.

2. Operating Cost of System:

- **Explanation:** Operating costs refer to the **ongoing expenses incurred to maintain and run the system after it's developed**. This includes costs like software licenses, maintenance and support, staff training, and any other costs associated with the day-to-day operation of the system.
- **Example:** Continuing with the sales order processing system example, operating costs might include fees for software updates, salaries for system administrators, and expenses for training employees to use the system effectively.

3. Benefits Obtained by System:

- **Explanation:** This step involves **identifying and estimating the benefits or advantages that the new system will bring to the organization**.

- These benefits can be tangible, such as increased revenue or cost savings, or intangible, such as improved customer satisfaction or employee productivity.
- **Example:** The benefits of a sales order processing system could include reduced processing time for orders, improved accuracy in order fulfillment, and better inventory management, leading to increased sales and customer satisfaction.

Step 2: Expressing Costs and Benefits in Common Units

1. Calculating Net Benefit:

- **Explanation:** **Net benefit** is **calculated** by **subtracting the total costs of the project from the total benefits obtained**. It represents the overall gain or loss resulting from implementing the new system.
- **Example:** If the total benefits of implementing the sales order processing system outweigh the total costs, then the net benefit would be positive, indicating a profitable investment. Conversely, if the costs exceed the benefits, the net benefit would be negative, suggesting a loss.

2. Expressing Costs and Benefits in Monetary Terms:

- **Explanation:** In order to compare costs and benefits accurately, they need to be expressed in a **common unit, typically monetary terms** (expressing values in the form of money or currency or assigning a specific financial value to it). This allows decision-makers to make informed choices based on the financial implications of the project.
- **Example:** All costs and benefits associated with the sales order processing system, such as development costs, operating expenses, and increased revenue, should be quantified in terms of money to facilitate comparison and analysis.

Types of Costs:

1. Development Costs:

- **Definition:** These costs encompass the **expenses related to the creation and construction** of the system. It includes salaries and other employment costs of the staff involved in developing the system.

- **Example:** If a company is developing a new software system, development costs would include the **salaries of programmers, designers, and other personnel** involved in the development process.

2. Setup Costs:

- **Definition:** Setup costs refer to the **expenses associated with the implementation and installation of the system**. This includes costs for hardware, file conversion, recruitment, and staff training needed to set up the system.
- **Example:** For a new inventory management system, setup costs might include **purchasing servers and computers, converting existing data files to the new system format, hiring additional staff to manage the implementation, and providing training to employees on how to use the new system**.

3. Operational Costs:

- **Definition:** Operational costs are the **ongoing expenses required to operate and maintain the system after it's installed**.

- This includes costs for **software licenses, maintenance, technical support**, and any other expenses associated with the day-to-day operation of the system.
- **Example:** Continuing with the inventory management system example, **operational costs would include fees for software updates, salaries for IT staff responsible for system maintenance, and expenses for technical support services.**

Categories of Benefits:

1. Direct Benefits:

- **Definition:** Direct benefits are those that are **directly obtained by using or operating the system**. These benefits are usually **tangible and measurable**.
- **Example:** If a company implements a new payroll system, a direct benefit would be the **reduction in salary processing time and associated labor costs due to automation**.

2. Assessable Indirect Benefits:

- **Definition:** Assessable indirect benefits, also known as **secondary benefits**, are obtained due to **improvements in the performance** of the current system. These benefits are indirectly linked to the system's operation and may be quantifiable.
- **Example:** In the case of a new customer relationship management (CRM) system, **a user-friendly interface may lead to a reduction in data entry errors**, resulting in increased efficiency and cost savings.

3. Intangible Benefits:

- **Definition:** Intangible benefits are **long-term and difficult to quantify benefits** that result from the system's operation. These benefits are often related to improvements in **employee satisfaction, morale, or organizational culture**.
- **Example:** If a company implements a new employee training system, an intangible benefit would be improved job satisfaction and employee retention, leading to lower turnover rates and reduced recruitment costs over time.

Cash Flow Forecasting:

1. What is Cash Flow?:

- Cash flow refers to the movement of money into and out of a business. It includes all the money that comes into the business (income or revenue) and all the money that goes out (expenditures or expenses).
- Forecasting refers to predicting or estimating future events or trends based on current information, historical data, and analysis

2. Importance of Cash Flow Forecasting:

- Cash flow forecasting is crucial because it helps businesses plan and manage their finances effectively.
- By predicting when money will be coming in and going out, businesses can anticipate potential cash shortages or surpluses and make informed decisions to address them.

3. Components of Cash Flow Forecasting:

- **Income/Revenue:** This includes all the money that the business expects to receive from sales, investments, loans, or any other sources.
- **Expenditures/Expenses:** These are the costs or payments that the business expects to make, such as salaries, rent, utilities, inventory purchases, loan repayments, and taxes.
- **Timing:** Cash flow forecasting also considers the timing of income and expenses. It estimates when money will be received and when it needs to be paid out. This timing aspect is crucial for managing cash flow effectively.

4. Negative Cash Flow During Development Stage:

- During the development stage of a project or business, expenditures often exceed income, leading to a negative cash flow.
- This is because significant investments are made upfront in areas like research, development, equipment purchase, and hiring staff.
- While money is being spent, revenue generation may not have started yet.

5. Positive Cash Flow During Operating Life:

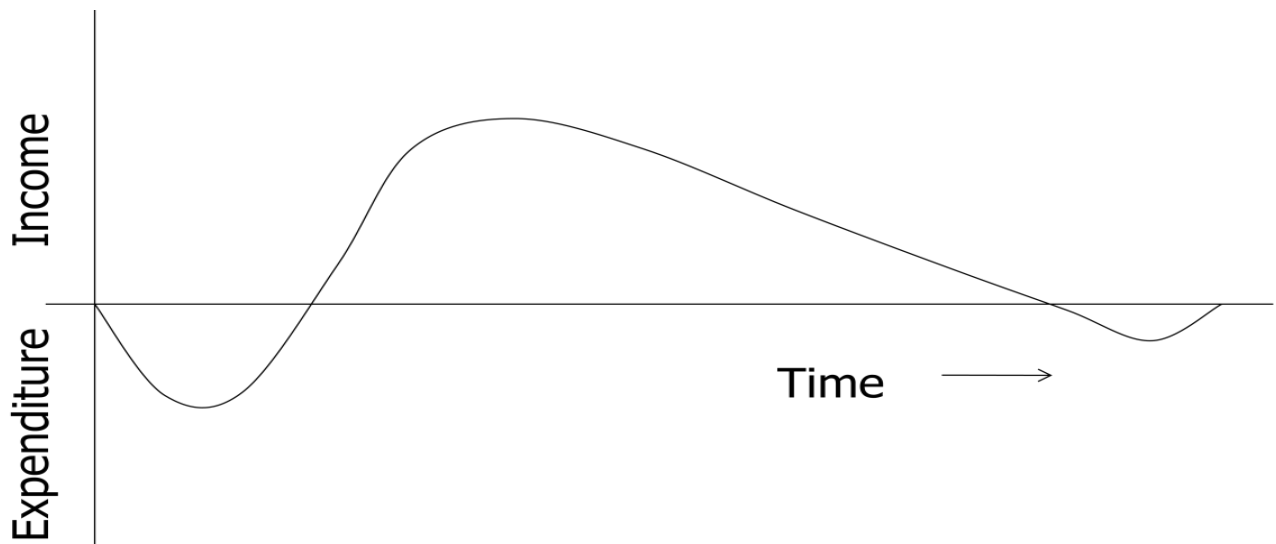
- Once the project or business is operational, and income starts flowing in from sales or other sources, the cash flow turns positive.
- This means that the business is **generating more income than it's spending on operating expenses**.
- Positive cash flow is **essential for sustaining and growing the business**.

6. Purpose of Cash Flow Forecasting:

- **Planning:** Cash flow forecasts help businesses **plan for upcoming expenses and ensure they have enough funds to cover them**. It allows them to make informed decisions about when to invest, when to save, and when to seek additional financing.
- **Managing Cash Flow:** By identifying potential **cash shortfalls or surpluses in advance**, businesses can take proactive measures to manage their cash flow effectively. This may involve adjusting spending, delaying payments, or pursuing additional revenue streams.

- **Decision Making:** Cash flow forecasts provide valuable insights for decision-making.

They help businesses evaluate the financial implications of various options and prioritize activities based on their impact on cash flow.



Example:

The following table illustrates cash flow forecasts for three projects. In each case it is assumed that the cash flows take place at the end of each year. Here negative values represent expenditure and positive values represent income.

Year	Project1	Project2	project3
0	-100000	-1,000,000	-120000
1	10,000	2,00000	30,000
2	10,000	2,00000	30,000
3	10,000	2,00000	30,000
4	20,000	2,00000	30,000
5	100000	3,00000	75,000

Cash flow forecasting or **cash flow management** is a key aspect of financial management of a business, planning its future cash requirements to avoid a crisis of liquidity

Steps to preparing a cash flow forecast:

1. Examine Previous Year's Monthly Financial Data:

- **Explanation:** To **make an accurate prediction** of future cash flows, it's important to **look at the financial data from the previous year, month by month.**

- This helps in understanding patterns and trends that can inform projections for the coming year.
- **Example:** If you're preparing a cash flow forecast for the year 2024, you would examine the financial data for each month of 2023 to understand the typical inflows and outflows of cash during different times of the year.

2. Design a Cash Flow Worksheet:

- **Explanation:** A cash flow worksheet is a tool that helps organize projected cash flows, including expected receipts (money coming in) and disbursements (money going out). It provides a structured format for recording and analyzing cash flow data.
- **Example:** You might create columns for each month of the year and rows for different categories of cash receipts and disbursements, such as sales revenue, expenses, payroll, taxes, and loan repayments.

3. Consider Cash Flow Receipts:

- **Explanation:** Cash flow receipts refer to the money that is expected to come into the business. This can include revenues from sales, taxes, grants, or other sources.

- **Example:** For new operations, you might compare the average monthly revenues of similar-sized municipalities or operations in your area to establish a benchmark. For existing operations, you could use data from the same month in the previous year, adjusting for any changes or special circumstances.

4. Consider Cash Flow Disbursements:

- **Explanation:** Cash flow disbursements are the **payments that the business expects to make**, such as salaries, rent, utilities, taxes, and loan repayments.
- **Example:** You would use information from past payroll records, pay dates for the coming year, and details about other expenses to estimate cash outflows. For example, if you typically pay suppliers within 30 days, you would schedule cash outlays accordingly.

5. Reconciliation of Cash Receipts to Cash Disbursements:

- **Explanation:** This step involves **reconciling (process of comparing two sets of records)** the cash receipts (money coming in) with the cash

disbursements (money going out) to ensure that there is enough cash to cover expenses.

- **Example:** You would start with the opening balance from the previous month, add the total receipts for the current month, and subtract the total disbursements. The resulting balance becomes the starting point for the next month's reconciliation.

Selecting the Appropriate Report:

Selecting the appropriate report involves identifying the type of information needed to convey, the audience it's intended for, and the purpose it serves.

1. Define the Purpose:

- Determine the **primary objective of the report**. Is it to inform, analyze, or propose a solution? **Understanding the purpose will guide the selection of the appropriate report format and content.**

2. Identify the Audience:

- **Consider who will be reading the report**. Are they executives, stakeholders, clients, or team members? Tailor the report's language, tone, and level of detail to match the audience's knowledge and preferences.

3. Consider the Content:

- **Evaluate the type of information that needs to be included in the report**. Will it contain textual explanations, data analysis, visualizations, or a combination of these elements? **Choose a report format** that best presents the content effectively.

4. Choose the Format:

- Based on the purpose, audience, and content requirements, select the most suitable report format. Common formats include:
 - Narrative Reports: Provide detailed explanations, analysis, and recommendations in a written format.
 - Visual Reports: Use charts, graphs, tables, and other visual elements to present data and findings in a concise and engaging manner.
 - Executive Summaries: Offer a condensed version of the main findings, conclusions, and recommendations for busy stakeholders.
 - Technical Reports: Include in-depth analysis, methodologies, and technical details relevant to a specialized audience.
 - Presentation Reports: Deliver key information through slides, accompanied by verbal explanations during a presentation.

5. Ensure Clarity and Readability:

- **Regardless of the chosen format, prioritize clarity and readability.** Use clear headings, subheadings, and bullet points to organize information logically. Maintain consistency in formatting, fonts, and styles to enhance readability.

6. Review and Revise:

- **Before finalizing the report, review it thoroughly to ensure accuracy,** coherence, and relevance. Revise as needed to eliminate errors, improve clarity, and strengthen the overall impact of the report.

7. Seek Feedback:

- If possible, gather feedback from colleagues, peers, or subject matter experts to validate the effectiveness of the report. Incorporate constructive feedback to enhance its quality and effectiveness.

Project Approach:

To develop a project an appropriate technology as well as model needs to be selected. The appropriate technology and process model leads to a successful project management, resource management and project is completed with in deadline.

Choosing Technologies:

1. Understanding Needs:

- Before choosing technologies, it's important to understand what the project requires. This involves identifying the specific functions the system needs to perform and any special requirements.

2. Exploring Options:

- Once the needs are clear, it's time to explore different technology options available. This may involve researching various software, hardware, and tools that can fulfill the project requirements.

3. Assessing Suitability:

- Each technology option should be evaluated based on how well it meets the project's needs. Consider factors like scalability, compatibility, cost-effectiveness, and ease of implementation.

4. Considering Future Growth:

- It's essential to choose technologies that can accommodate future growth and changes in requirements. Scalability and flexibility are key factors to consider to ensure the longevity of the solution.

5. Making Informed Decisions:

- Ultimately, the goal is to make informed decisions about which technologies to adopt based on their alignment with the project goals, budget constraints, and long-term sustainability.

Choice of Process Model:

1. Understanding Process Models:

- A process model outlines the steps and activities involved in developing the project from start to finish. Different process models offer various approaches to project management and development.

2. Selecting the Right Model:

- The choice of process model depends on factors such as project size, complexity, timeline, and organizational preferences. Common models include Agile, Waterfall, Scrum, and Spiral.

3. Adapting to Project Needs:

- It's crucial to adapt the chosen process model to suit the specific needs of the project. This may involve customizing workflows, timelines, and methodologies to ensure a smooth development process.

4. Ensuring Collaboration:

- Effective collaboration among team members is essential for the success of any project. The chosen process model should facilitate communication, coordination, and teamwork throughout the project lifecycle.

5. Continuous Improvement:

- Project teams should regularly evaluate the effectiveness of the chosen process model and make adjustments as needed. Continuous improvement ensures that the project stays on track and delivers optimal results.

Structured Method:

1. Planning and Preparation:

- The structured method begins with thorough planning and preparation. This involves defining project goals, objectives, scope, and requirements in detail.

2. Organizing Resources:

- Once the project is underway, resources such as personnel, tools, and materials are organized and allocated according to the project plan.

3. Following Defined Procedures:

- The structured method follows defined procedures and guidelines at each stage of the project. This ensures consistency, efficiency, and quality in project execution.

4. Monitoring Progress:

- Progress is continuously monitored and tracked against predefined milestones and deliverables. This helps identify any deviations from the plan and allows for timely corrective action.

5. Evaluating and Iterating:

- After project completion, a thorough evaluation is conducted to assess its success and identify areas for improvement. Lessons learned are incorporated into future projects to refine and enhance the structured method over time.